



of the landscape of the narrator's childhood, its strife-ridden backdrop, down to the details of the family's purchases at Jalal Sons supermarket. This sombre, almost heavy-handed detailing is for the most part pleasurable, but at times lingers overly on minutiae. However, it is ultimately as a miniaturist that Sethi triumphs; Zakia's holiday in Nathiagali, for example, has all the compelling quality of a short story. If rambling at times and slow to catch, the wishmaker's world enthralls, putting one in mind of that great Indian coming of age novel, *The Shadow Lines*.

Inspired by Tolstoy, who he is at the moment reading, Sethi is young (at 24 going on 25, he is just about as old as his former teacher at Harvard, Zadie Smith, was, when she was first published), and refreshingly humble about his big debut; he launches Penguin's Hamish Hamilton imprint in India. He is in London at present, but plans to return to Lahore to live. About his future, he says, "I don't know what's next. I might record an album. I might become a teacher. I'd like to keep a journal, though. I think that's where the next project will come from." Elegant and restrained, here is a writer and a second novel—or collection of short stories—to watch out for.

EXCERPT

The sounds came from behind the door, and the wife heard them and awoke. They were tapping on the door; then they broke past it. There were many of them, policemen in uniforms and also in ordinary clothes, and they had rifles and guns with which they beat the editor, who was sitting up in his bed. The editor's wife asked to see an arrest warrant. One of the officers said he'd show her a death warrant instead.

They tied her arms and locked her in the bathroom, and they took the editor away.

It was reported in the newspapers. They were saying he had made a speech in India, an anti-Pakistan speech in which he'd criticised his own country; and the government was saying that it amounted to an act of treason, and could lead to a trial in a military court. Some had even written in to say that he was a spy for the Indian agencies and not really a Muslim.

'They are saying it,' said Daadi, who had read the columns in the Urdu newspapers. 'There must be some truth in what they are saying.'

My mother said, 'That's what they'll say when they come for me tomorrow.' It was morning and

'And the poet looked blankly at the faces around him, held up his glass and shook it contemplatively, and motioned with an open palm towards the sprightly girl on the stool with the light bulb in her hand and said, '*Bhai inquilaab tau tum lao gi*'—and of Daadi's childhood memories of Partition. What is missing, though, is more of a sense of Multan and what transpires there, in the second, somewhat slight part of the novel, where Samar's feudal roots come to bear on her fate. The dramatisation of what happens there is underplayed, to the detriment of what the reader has been so carefully set up for. For the bulk of the novel persists in giving us every detail